

# HOW DO YOU KNOW IT WORKS?

It is the first question a skeptical colleague asks about anything you built with AI, and **almost nobody can answer it**. "I clicked around and it seemed fine" is not an answer. Neither is "the AI said it was done."

## The answer is a list, and it fits on one sticky note.

Six cases that must be true. You write them down *once*, before you change anything, and you run them after every single change the AI makes. **That is the whole method**, and it is the difference between a tool you trust in front of thirty children and one you hope about.

## Why this matters more with AI than without it

When you build something yourself, you know which part you just touched. **When AI rewrites a file, you do not**. It will fix what you asked and quietly change three things you did not, in the same confident reply, and nothing in the conversation tells you which. **The list is how you find out** in ninety seconds instead of in front of a class.

## You do not need thirty test files

The software I run for my own high school woodshop course has thirty of them, covering money, fractions, board-foot math, scoring, placement, timing, resuming after a reload and safety. **You need six lines on paper**. The discipline is identical and the effort is not remotely comparable.

## Inside, in five pages

The six checks worth writing down · **why you test the refusals rather than the successes** · the order that makes the list useful instead of decorative · a worked list for a real tool, and the three things it caught · and a fill-in page so you leave with your own.

## Six checks, and they cover almost everything

These are not six checks about *your* tool. They are the six **shapes** of thing that break, and almost every real bug in a small classroom tool is one of them.

| # | The check                                                                        | What it catches                                                            |
|---|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 | <b>The ordinary case.</b> One normal thing, done the normal way.                 | That it works at all. Run it first and never skip it.                      |
| 2 | <b>The empty case.</b> No names in the list, no questions typed, nothing chosen. | The crash on a Monday morning before you have put anything in.             |
| 3 | <b>The last one.</b> The final item, the last seat, the thirtieth student.       | Counting that is off by one, which is the single most common bug there is. |
| 4 | <b>The duplicate.</b> The same name twice, the same answer twice.                | Two children called Jack. It will happen in September.                     |
| 5 | <b>The reload.</b> Close it, open it again, and look.                            | A tool that forgets. The difference between an app and a picture.          |
| 6 | <b>The refusal.</b> Ask it to do the thing it should not allow.                  | The next page is about this one, because it is the one everybody skips.    |

### Make each one a sentence, not a category

"The empty case" is a reminder. **"Open it with no students in the list and press Shuffle — it should say the list is empty, not freeze"** is a check. The difference is that the second one has an answer, so somebody else could run it, and so could you in March when you have forgotten everything.

**Write what should happen, not just what to do.** A check with no expected result is a thing you look at and then decide you are happy with.

### Six is the number for a reason

Long enough to catch the shapes above. **Short enough that you will actually run it** after a change you think is trivial, which is exactly when it earns its keep. A list of twenty gets run once and then admired.

## Test the refusals, not the successes

Everybody checks that the thing works. **Almost nobody checks that it stops.** And the refusals are what you need in front of a class, because that is where the embarrassment lives.

### What a refusal looks like in a classroom tool

**Selling the last one.** Stock reaches zero. Does the next tap say "sold out" or does it quietly sell a thing you do not have?

**Booking a taken slot.** Does it say so, or does it look like it worked?

**Deleting something that matters.** Does it ask first? Does it refuse outright? **"It just did it" is an answer you only get once.**

### And the refusal that is really a message

A tool that cannot do what you asked should **say which thing it could not do and why.** "Error" is not a refusal, it is a shrug. When AI writes you an error message, that message is a feature it wrote without being asked to think about — **read it, and make it say something a tired adult can act on.**

## Write the check before you prompt

This is the habit that costs nothing and changes everything, and it is about order rather than effort.

### 1 Decide what should be true afterward

One sentence, written down, **before** you type the prompt. "After this, booking a taken slot should say which slot and offer the next free one."

### 2 Then prompt

Ask for the change. Let it do whatever it does.

### 3 Then run the whole list, not just the new bit

All six, every time. **The new thing usually works; it is checks two and five that have quietly stopped working,** and you would never have looked.

### Why the order matters more than it sounds.

If you decide what "worked" means *after* you see the result, you are not checking it. **You are being persuaded by it,** and a confident reply is very persuasive at half past four.

## A six-line list for a classroom store, and what it caught

A small tool that sells class-money items to students: a shelf, a price, a stock count, a running total. Here is the whole list, in the form a sentence with an expected result.

### THE LIST, ON ONE STICKY NOTE

- 1 Sell one sticker. Total goes up by the sticker price, stock drops by one.
- 2 Open with an empty shelf. It says there is nothing to sell.  
It does not show a blank screen.
- 3 Sell the last eraser. Stock shows zero.
- 4 Sell a second last eraser. It refuses and says sold out.
- 5 Add two items both called "pencil". Both still sell separately.
- 6 Close the tab, reopen. Shelf, stock and total are all still there.

### What it caught, and none of these were visible by clicking around

**Check 4.** The last item sold, and then sold again, and the stock went to minus one. **The screen looked completely normal.**

**Check 6.** A later change moved where the total was kept, and the total stopped surviving a reload while everything else did. **Nothing about that change looked like it was near the total.**

**Check 2.** An empty shelf showed a blank white page, which is the version a teacher sees first, on the morning they open it before putting anything in. **The worst possible first impression, and the easiest to miss,** because you never open your own tool empty after the first day.

### Three bugs, six lines, about four minutes a run

That is the entire argument. **It is not thorough and it is not meant to be.** It is the cheapest thing that stops you finding out in front of a class.

## Write the list for something you already use

A tool you built, a spreadsheet you rely on, or one somebody handed you. Each line is **what you do** and **what should happen**. If you cannot say what should happen, that is the finding.

The thing I am checking:

| # | What I do    | What should happen |
|---|--------------|--------------------|
| 1 | ordinary     |                    |
| 2 | empty        |                    |
| 3 | the last one |                    |
| 4 | duplicate    |                    |
| 5 | reload       |                    |
| 6 | refusal      |                    |

### Run it now. What failed?

☐ Nothing ☐ One of them ☐ More than one

### If you want to watch this done with a whole staff

Our **Vibe Coding Staff PD** is a ready-to-run session with the full script, where every teacher leaves with a working tool they built. **"How do you know it works"** is the question that session exists to answer. Search our store.

### If this was useful, would you leave a review?

TPT gives you credit toward future purchases, and reviews decide whether another teacher sees this.